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CAMPAIGN CONTRIBUTIONS & BUREAUCRATIC OVERSIGHT: A CASE STUDY OF FERC

POWELL, JUDGE-LORD, & GRIMMER

RACHEL AUGUSTINE POTTER
CSDP FELLOW

**ASSISTANT PROFESSOR
DEPARTMENT OF POLITICS
UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA**

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SUMMARY

- **Big picture:** How do campaign contributions influence Members' behavior?
 - Roll call votes → High traceability
 - Letter-marking → Low traceability

- **Research question:** How do campaign contributions influence Members' letter-marking behavior?
 - Build on Arnold's concepts of *traceability* and *anticipation*
 - Identify correlations that exist in the data between campaign contributions from PACs in the energy sector and letter-writing by members of Congress on behalf of energy companies

- **Preliminary findings:** Republicans and those who get PAC \$ write more letters on behalf of energy companies
 - Suggests campaign contributions can buy influence!

MAIN CONTRIBUTIONS

- Massive data collection of letters sent by MCs to agencies
 - 200 FOIA requests, 1000s of letters
- Code letters into who written on behalf of and position (pro vs. con)
- Terrific insight into *how* MCs allocate their oversight behavior (e.g., Rep Mooney) and, critically, *why* they are doing it (e.g., constituency service vs. placating donors)
- Deep dive into FERC helps us to understand mechanics of what is happening with letter-marking

FOR THIS PAPER

- Why the focus on PAC contributions as opposed to lobbying?
- FERC is different than other agencies
 - What Wilson (1989) called a “client agency”
 - Not much “constituency service” to be done
 - Link to Arnold’s “inattentive publics”?
- More context on what FERC is doing during this time period
 - Regulations, grants, project approvals, licenses, enforcement, etc.
- Explain how you determined if a letter was pro or con business

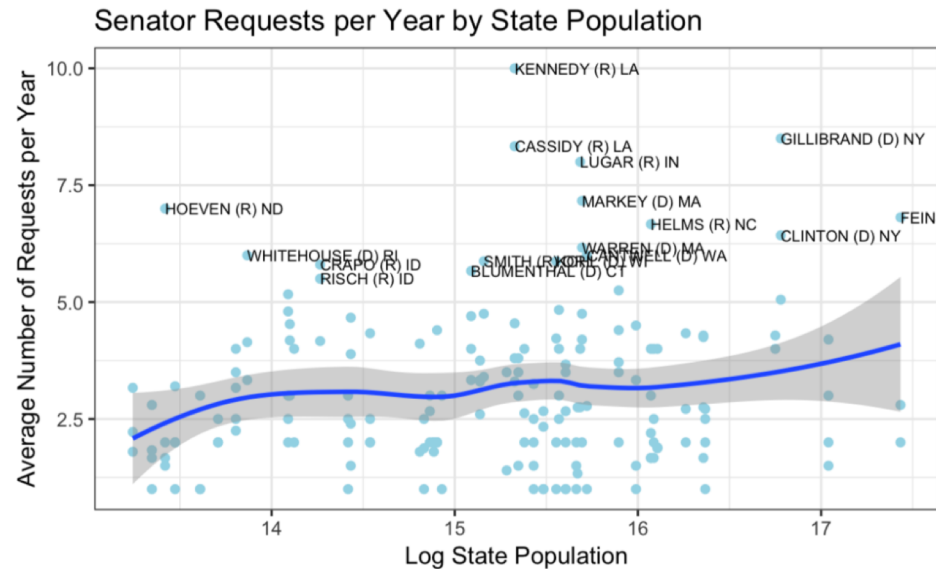
FOR THE BROADER PROJECT - THEORETICAL

- Give careful consideration to agency type (e.g., client agency vs. entrepreneurial agency)
- Give more careful consideration to the types of policy actions that Members write letters about (e.g., regulations, grants, project approvals, licenses, enforcement, etc.)
 - Variation in visibility/ traceability
 - Web-scraping potential suggests public availability
 - FERC participates in www.regulations.gov

FOR THE BROADER PROJECT - EMPIRICAL

- What about firms in MCs districts? They likely give \$\$ too, but writing on their behalf is in constituents' interest
 - Three cases – firms in district that give \$, firms in district that don't give \$, & firms out of district that give \$
- Consider the “multiplier effect” of letters that have multiple signatories
 - Esp. in differences in majority vs minority party – does GOP have a different approach?
- Use DUNS numbers to link parent and subsidiary companies?

MORE EMPIRICAL CONSIDERATIONS



- Population demand → all House members have the same demand function?
- Measure demand by jobs (per 1000) in the energy sector?

WHAT ABOUT SEN BOB GRAHAM?



Senator Bob Graham

Florida Governor 1979-1987

US Senator 1987-2005

Personal
business
interest?

September 30, 2014

Mr. Phillip D. Moeller
Commissioner
Federal Energy Regulatory Commission
888 First Street, N.E.
Washington, D.C. 20426

RE: Sabal Pipeline PF14-1

Dear Commissioner Moeller,

It has been brought to my attention that in a recent report submitted into the official docket (Access No. 20140910-5159) Sabal Trail has included the following statement located under the Routing/Alternatives Update Section of their report:

“Sabal Trail evaluated the requested changes in the proposed pipeline route on Graham properties and an acceptable route was developed.”

While access was granted to Sabal Trail to conduct civil, environmental and cultural surveys, I would like the record to reflect that Graham Angus in no way supports the route proposed across farm property and has made no such requests or agreements with Sabal Trail regarding this matter.

I appreciate your attention to my concerns and look forward to your confirmation that the matters addressed in this letter have been correctly reported.

Sincerely,

Bob Graham